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Ireland

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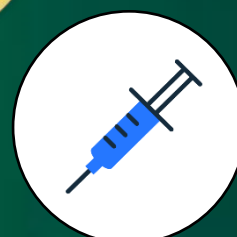
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AI That You Can Trust

Why Us?

Stay on the right side of history. At AI & Partners, we believe AI should unlock potential—not cause harm. We've seen the fear and fallout when teams lose control of AI, but also the trust and innovation that follow when it's handled responsibly. That's why we exist: to help you build AI you can trust and stand behind—for the long run.

80%

of AI systems
are unknown

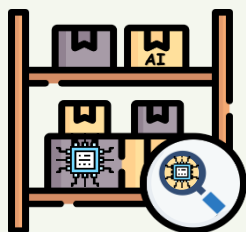
What Do We Do?

We enable safe AI usage—for your organization and your clients. Unknown AI adoption leads to confusion, risk, and reputational damage. We help you take control with tools to identify, monitor, and govern all AI systems—so you're not reacting to AI, you're leading it.

How Do We Do It?

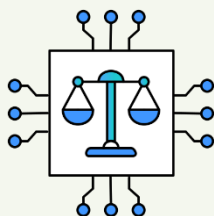
Do you know what AI systems you have? Identify all known and unknown AI systems (algorithms, LLMs, prompts, and models) from all internal and external AI vendors, automated by generating your inventory. Overall, 80% of AI inventory is unknown to our clients.

How do you guarantee ongoing safe AI use? Continuously monitor deployed AI systems for performance drift, anomalies or failures, real-world impacts, and emerging risks (e.g. data poisoning). Any malfunction of an AI system has severe implications for organisations (e.g. inability to assess online misinformation that leads to widespread public mistrust), so monitoring becomes a matter of urgency.



AI Discovery & AI Inventory

Automatically detect all AI systems, including models, algorithms, and prompts, and maintain a live, always-updated register for full visibility and compliance.



Responsible AI

Embed fairness, transparency, and control into every stage of AI use—aligning with the EU AI Act and building 'Trustworthy-by-Design'.



Model Monitoring

Continuously track your AI models after deployment to detect drift, bias, or failure—so you stay in control and prevent harm before it happens.

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Overview

Ireland's AI Strategy builds on its commitment to democratic values and societal well-being to responsibly deploy and govern AI. The strategy emphasizes a human-centric approach, the democratization of AI, and sustainable innovation, with a firm commitment to European collaboration and global standards.

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is rapidly transforming societies and economies worldwide, and Ireland is navigating its AI governance pathway in alignment with broader EU objectives. Embracing AI's potential while addressing emerging risks, Ireland has adopted a values-driven, innovation-friendly, and EU-aligned approach to AI governance. Rather than developing sweeping national legislation, Ireland is implementing the European Union's AI Act, while supplementing it with domestic frameworks, sectoral initiatives, and strategic tools to ensure responsible, secure, and transparent AI deployment.

At the core of Ireland's AI governance strategy is its alignment with the EU AI Act (Regulation 2024/1689), which entered into force on August 2, 2024, with provisions on prohibited AI practices enforceable since February 2, 2025. This is operationalized through the upcoming Regulation of Artificial Intelligence Bill, which is in its Spring 2025 Legislation Programme and will aim to implement the EU AI Act domestically. Existing national instruments such as the Data Protection Act 2018 (DPA) and the Copyright and Related Rights Act 2000 (CRRRA) also influence AI deployment. These measures are reinforced by the obligation to perform data protection impact assessments, particularly for AI systems that impact citizens' rights, as mandated by the GDPR. These tools are complemented by targeted sectoral efforts—ranging from the establishment of national AI testbeds to a strong focus on data governance and intellectual property, which foster ethical data usage and secure AI development.

Ireland's institutional AI governance structure is coordinated across multiple agencies. While a lead regulator for the AI Act is expected to be designated, the Irish Government has approved a distributed model of implementation, with an initial list of eight public bodies designated as competent authorities.

The Data Protection Commission (DPC) plays a key role in embedding governance principles within public policy, particularly concerning the intersection of AI and personal data. The AI Advisory Council, established as part of the National AI Strategy, provides independent advice to the Government on AI policy, covering areas from start-up ecosystems to AI literacy for educators.

Ireland's AI governance is also shaped by its commitment to international standards. AI is a key pillar of Ireland's "AI – Here for Good" strategy, which aligns closely with the principles in the AI Act. Through its active participation in EU initiatives and standardisation platforms, and the DPC's engagement with the European Data Protection Board (EDPB), Ireland advances a coordinated vision rooted in democratic values, human rights, and technological sovereignty.

As outlined in its National AI Strategy, Ireland envisions AI as a critical enabler of digital transformation, sustainable development, and global competitiveness. Strategic priorities include building innovation capacity through initiatives like developing a national AI-focused start-up ecosystem and national AI testbeds, promoting SME participation through supportive ecosystems, and expanding AI education through training programs and skill development initiatives, including AI literacy for educators. Tools such as the ethical principles embedded in the National AI Strategy and the guidance from the DPC foster ethical and human-centric AI design from the outset, ensuring safeguards against discrimination and bias.

Through a combination of EU harmonization, national infrastructure development, and global engagement, Ireland is advancing a governance model that balances technological leadership with democratic accountability. This approach positions Ireland as a committed and capable actor in shaping the future of responsible, human-centric AI in Europe.





Specific AI Governance or Law

Ireland has no standalone AI law but follows the EU AI Act, effective August 2024, with prohibited practices enforceable since February 2025 and full implementation expected by August 2026. A national bill is planned. The Data Protection Commission oversees AI-related data use under GDPR, issuing guidance and initiating investigations into AI data practices.

Specific AI Governance in Ireland

Ireland has not enacted standalone national legislation exclusively for AI, but the use of AI is governed by the EU AI Act (Regulation 2024/1689), which entered into force on August 2, 2024, and began to apply on a phased basis from February 2, 2025. Prohibited AI practices under the AI Act have been in force in Ireland since February 2, 2025. Full implementation across high-risk and general-purpose AI systems is anticipated by August 2026.

The Irish Government has announced that the Regulation of Artificial Intelligence Bill is in its Spring 2025 Legislation Programme, which will aim to implement the AI Act in Ireland. Data protection in Ireland is primarily governed by the GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018 (DPA). While neither specifically addresses AI, the GDPR applies to AI technologies that process personal data of EU/EEA data subjects. The Irish Data Protection Commission (DPC) actively focuses on the use of personal data by AI technologies.

The DPC has initiated actions and investigations related to organizations' use of personal data to train AI tools, including Meta, X, and Google Ireland Limited. The DPC also requested an opinion from the European Data Protection Board (EDPB) on the use of personal data for the development and deployment of AI models. The DPC has published guidance on AI, Large Language Models, and Data Protection, noting potential personal data processing risks. Organizations using AI products may be considered data controllers and should obtain information from third-party AI product providers regarding personal data usage and retention.

This information should be provided to data subjects, and providers should have appropriate personal data governance. The AI Act does not affect obligations of providers and deployers of AI systems as data controllers or processors, with the GDPR continuing to apply where AI systems involve personal data processing. However, the AI Act recognizes the importance of privacy and data governance, requiring measures to ensure data protection principles like data minimization are followed throughout the AI system's lifecycle.



AI Ethics Guidelines and Sectoral Governance Tools

Ireland has a national AI strategy titled "AI – Here for Good" ("National AI Strategy"), in place since 2021, which aligns with the principles in the AI Act. As part of this strategy, an advisory body, the AI Advisory Council, was established to independently advise the Government on AI policy. The Council has published several advice papers, including a report in February 2025 with recommendations for a national AI-focused start-up ecosystem, national AI testbeds, AI literacy for educators, and protecting creators from AI misuse. The Government has stated it will give full consideration to this report. Copyright in Ireland is governed by the Copyright and Related Rights Act 2000 (CRRA). Under the CRRA, the author of an "original" work is the individual who owns the copyright. The CRRA also covers "computer-generated" works, defining the first author as "the person by whom the arrangements necessary for the creation of the work are undertaken". It appears AI technology cannot own copyright, and the author must be a human or legal entity, though it is unclear whether copyright is created by entering a prompt into an AI system or by the program's designer(s). Issues regarding copyright ownership and the right to use copyrighted works may arise with AI, as many AI systems are trained on large datasets, often comprising original works subject to copyright. The CRRA includes text and data mining (TDM) exceptions, allowing copying for non-commercial research and commercial TDM purposes unless the copyright holder expressly reserves their rights. If copyright holders opt-out, it could limit AI developers' ability to use third-party works without infringement risk. While Irish courts have not ruled on copyright in publicly available content used for AI training, cases in other jurisdictions indicate AI output may infringe IP. For instance, Getty Images is suing Stability AI in the UK for scraping images and alleged infringement by Stable Diffusion's output.

In terms of patents, Irish law, under the Patents Act 1992, appears to prevent an AI system from being designated as an inventor. The European Patent Office (EPO) has confirmed that under the European Patent Convention, an inventor must be a human being, although patentable inventions are not limited to those devised by humans. AI-based patent applications have also been refused due to insufficient disclosure, as AI systems may not be comprehensible or accessible enough for humans to describe their processes. There are no specific competition rules governing AI in Ireland. Ireland's Competition and Consumer Protection Commission (CCPC) has outlined implications of AI for competition and consumer protection, noting that AI can assist competition but also carries the risk of algorithmic collusion. The CCPC believes that the market power of those with access to large amounts of data should not be further strengthened and that access to such data should be fair, reasonable, and non-discriminatory. They also suggested accompanying infrastructure to prevent disadvantages for SMEs and encourage open datasets.





Proposed AI Regulatory Authority and Future Outlook

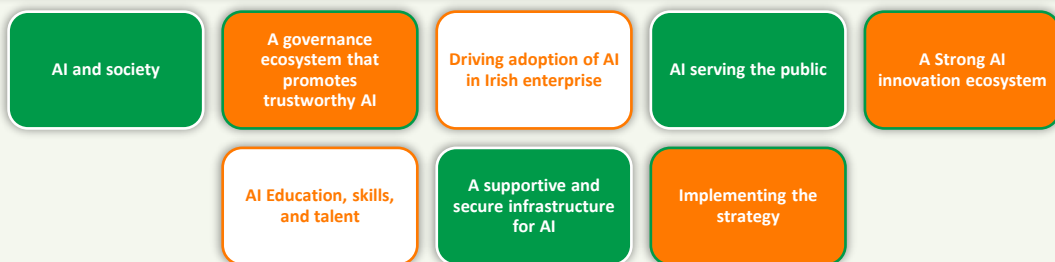
The Irish Government has approved a recommendation for Ireland to adopt a distributed model of implementation for the AI Act. An initial list of eight public bodies has been approved as competent authorities responsible for implementing and enforcing the AI Act within their respective sectors, including the Central Bank of Ireland, Commission for Communications Regulation, CCPC, DPC, and Health and Safety Authority. A lead regulator is expected to be designated to coordinate enforcement and provide centralized functions. Looking forward, Ireland's AI governance trajectory will be shaped by its integration into the broader EU AI framework, domestic legislative evolution, and sectoral priorities. National discussions continue on expanding protections around workplace AI use and data ethics, while industry and research sectors anticipate greater clarity on AI liability, copyright, and generative model governance. In the workplace, there are no specific laws solely for AI, but employers' use of AI tools must comply with the Employment Equality Acts 1998–2015 to prevent discrimination. Data protection considerations are also crucial, and high-risk activities like candidate selection or performance review using AI will likely require a data protection impact assessment under GDPR Article 35. GDPR Article 22 protects individuals from automated decision-making, requiring human oversight. The AI Act classifies AI systems used in employment for recruitment, work allocation, evaluations, promotions, and terminations as high-risk, with rules commencing in August 2026. The civil liability framework for defective products in Ireland is set out in the Liability for Defective Products Act 1991. This has been updated by the Revised EU Product Liability Directive (EU) 2024/2853, which entered into force in December 2024 and will apply from December 9, 2026. The Revised PLD expands the meaning of "product" to include software and AI systems, potentially making AI providers liable for defective AI systems. It excludes free and open-source software not developed or used commercially. The proposed AI Liability Directive (AILD), intended to complement the AI Act, was withdrawn due to lack of agreement.

The risk of discrimination and bias in AI systems is a recognized concern, as algorithms trained on outdated or unrepresentative data can produce discriminatory outputs. The AI Act acknowledges this risk and emphasizes the importance of high-quality datasets and data governance practices to prevent and mitigate biases. In Irish law, the Equal Status Acts 2000–2018 prohibit discrimination in various areas based on nine protected grounds. The Employment Equality Act 1998 prohibits workplace discrimination on the same grounds. AI systems processing personal data with biased outputs may infringe fairness and transparency principles under Irish data protection law. The National AI Strategy highlights the need for safeguards to address discrimination and bias in AI, particularly in public service use.



Discussion: Ireland's National AI Strategy

Ireland's AI governance approach is grounded in a values-based, human-centric framework that emphasizes responsible, secure, and public good-oriented development of AI. Anchored in the principles of trust, transparency, and European values, the strategy promotes proportionate regulation and international cooperation. Rather than relying solely on prescriptive legislation, Ireland fosters AI through structured ecosystems, research excellence, and cross-sector collaboration—supported by initiatives like the AI Advisory Council and national AI testbeds.



Analysis

Ireland's AI strategy, "AI – Here for Good," reflects a comprehensive commitment to embedding AI within a framework of ethical, legal, and societal considerations. The strategy centers on the notion of "AI made for good," underpinned by democratic values and fundamental rights, and aligns with global principles. While the European Union's AI Act advances binding regulations, Ireland complements this with a governance approach that integrates sector-specific innovation with principled oversight, particularly through national guidance and the establishment of competent authorities. A distinguishing feature of Ireland's approach is its emphasis on integration within the European and international context. As an EU Member State, Ireland is directly subject to the provisions of the EU AI Act. Regulatory efforts aim to ensure both innovation and accountability, focusing on data protection, transparency, and the prevention of bias, especially for high-risk applications. The Data Protection Commission (DPC) actively focuses on the use of personal data by AI technologies and has published guidance on AI, Large Language Models, and Data Protection. Ireland's AI governance also supports adaptive implementation mechanisms. The AI Advisory Council has recommended the development of national AI testbeds across multiple sectors to operate in parallel with the sandbox framework provided for in the AI Act. These platforms promote experimental use, iterative learning, and feedback-informed policymaking, allowing for evidence-based adjustments to governance frameworks in response to emerging challenges.

Another hallmark of Ireland's strategy is its systemic focus on embedding AI across sectors through specialized infrastructure and ethical guidelines. Distributed responsibility is promoted via shared participation by government, industry, academia, and civil society, exemplified by the AI Advisory Council which independently advises the Government on AI policy. The strategy stresses the importance of high-quality datasets for high-risk AI systems to ensure they perform as intended and do not become a source of discrimination. Ireland further prioritizes capacity-building through initiatives supporting AI literacy. The AI Advisory Council has recommended that the Irish Government lead the development and implementation of AI literacy for educators across all education levels and publish guidelines for the use of generative AI tools. The strategy places a strong emphasis on inclusion, ensuring equitable access to AI benefits and addressing potential risks of discrimination and bias in AI systems. Lastly, Ireland champions dynamic and sustainable governance. The "AI – Here for Good" strategy outlines a forward-looking vision that addresses the dual imperatives of technological leadership and societal well-being. This allows Ireland to remain competitive while reinforcing public trust and democratic accountability in the age of AI, particularly through its commitment to the responsible and human-centric deployment of AI.



Ireland's Approach to AI Regulation and Governance

Ireland has adopted a structured, EU-aligned approach to AI governance, centred on harmonisation with the EU AI Act, strategic investment in innovation, and safeguarding fundamental rights. While national legislation directly regulating AI remains limited, Ireland actively shapes AI policy through international collaboration, sectoral integration, and the development of enabling frameworks that support trustworthy AI deployment.

1. Regulatory and Strategic Frameworks

Ireland's AI governance is fundamentally anchored within the broader European regulatory landscape. Instead of pursuing standalone national AI legislation, Ireland aligns its regulatory strategy with the EU AI Act (Regulation 2024/1689), which forms the cornerstone of AI regulation across all EU Member States. As of February 2, 2025, provisions on prohibited AI practices under the AI Act are directly applicable in Ireland. The AI Act itself entered into force on August 2, 2024, and began to apply on a phased basis since February 2, 2025, with full implementation due to continue until 2030. Nationally, the Irish Government has announced that the Regulation of Artificial Intelligence Bill is in its Spring 2025 Legislation Programme. This Bill will aim to implement the AI Act in Ireland, though specific information about its content is currently limited. Ireland embeds AI governance into existing statutory frameworks. Data protection is primarily governed by the GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018 (DPA). While neither specifically addresses AI, the GDPR clearly applies to AI technologies that involve processing personal data of EU/EEA data subjects. Similarly, copyright in Ireland is governed by the Copyright and Related Rights Act 2000 (CRRA), which includes provisions for "computer-generated" works. Civil liability for defective products is addressed by the Liability for Defective Products Act 1991, updated by the revised EU Product Liability Directive (EU) 2024/2853, which will apply to software and AI systems.



2. Institutional Support and Strategic Missions

The Irish Government coordinates AI governance through various public bodies. The DPC, for example, actively focuses on the use of personal data by AI technologies and has initiated investigations and requested opinions on this topic. Strategically, Ireland has a national AI strategy titled "AI – Here for Good" ("National AI Strategy"), which has been in place since 2021 and closely aligns with the principles in the AI Act. As part of this strategy, an advisory body, the AI Advisory Council, has been established to independently advise the Government on AI policy. The Council has published several advice papers, including a report in February 2025 with recommendations for a national AI-focused start-up ecosystem, national AI testbeds, AI literacy for educators, and protecting creators from AI misuse. The Government has announced it will give this report full consideration.



3. Standards Development and Global Engagement

Ireland, as an EU Member State, participates in shaping EU-wide AI standards and contributes to global AI discourse. The DPC, for instance, requested an opinion from the European Data Protection Board (EDPB) on the use of personal data for the development and deployment of AI models, seeking consistent regulation in this area. Domestically, the DPC has published guidance on AI, Large Language Models, and Data Protection. Ireland's National AI Strategy also emphasizes that the use of AI within the public service must be actively informed by an assessment of potential human rights and equality implications. The AI Act itself provides that the right to privacy and protection of personal data must be guaranteed throughout the entire lifecycle of the AI system.

4. Sectoral and Extended Regulatory Approaches

Ireland's AI governance approach supports sectoral integration within a unified EU framework. While there are no AI-specific national sectoral laws, existing legal instruments across employment, product liability, and copyright law intersect with AI use cases. For instance, in an employment context, AI tools utilized by employers must comply with the Employment Equality Acts 1998–2015 to ensure decisions do not discriminate based on protected characteristics. The use of AI technologies for functions such as candidate selection or employee performance review are likely to be "high-risk" activities requiring a data protection impact assessment under Article 35 of the GDPR. The AI Act also classifies the use of AI systems in employment for recruitment, selection, work allocation, evaluations, promotions, terminations, and redundancies as high-risk, with rules for these systems commencing in August 2026.



5. Fostering Innovation and Indigenous Development

Ireland aims to position itself as a key player in AI development. The AI Advisory Council's recommendations include developing a national AI-focused start-up ecosystem and national AI testbeds across multiple sectors to operate in parallel to the sandbox framework provided for in the AI Act. A study by Ireland's Central Statistics Office found that in 2024, 15.2% of all Irish enterprises use AI technologies in some form, with large and medium-sized enterprises commonly using AI to automate workflows or assist in decision-making, and small enterprises mainly using AI for natural language generation.

6. AI in Public Sector Transformation

AI is an integral part of Ireland's vision for digital government reform. The National AI Strategy states that the use of AI within the public service must be actively informed by an assessment of potential human rights and equality implications. The AI Advisory Council has recommended that any decision allowing An Garda Síochána (Ireland's police force) to use facial recognition technology should be based on national, primary legislation setting out the legal basis, permitted use cases, and legal perimeters for compiling facial recognition databases. A coordinated oversight framework is in development to ensure that AI deployments meet the accountability and transparency standards outlined in the EU AI Act. The Irish Government has approved a distributed model of implementation for the AI Act, with an initial list of eight public bodies designated as competent authorities for AI oversight within their respective sectors.



7. AI Skills, Education and Inclusion

Ireland's AI strategy includes a strong emphasis on digital skills development and inclusive participation. Article 4 of the AI Act requires employers to ensure their workforce using AI systems for work has a sufficient level of AI literacy, an obligation that took effect on February 2, 2025. The AI Advisory Council has recommended that the Irish Government lead the development and implementation of AI literacy for educators across all education levels and publish guidelines for the use of generative AI tools. The AI Act recognizes the risk of discrimination and bias in AI systems and provides that AI systems should be developed to promote equal access, gender equality, and cultural diversity, while avoiding discriminatory impacts. The National AI Strategy emphasizes the essential need for safeguards to address the risk of discrimination and bias in AI.

8. Infrastructure, Compute and Data Foundations

Ireland is investing in infrastructure to support AI scale-up. The AI Advisory Council's recommendation to develop national AI testbeds across multiple sectors highlights a commitment to providing environments for real-world experimentation. Ireland's approach encourages data interoperability and responsible data access while safeguarding privacy and security. The DPC's actions and guidance demonstrate a strong focus on consistent data protection practices across AI systems and the impact of the GDPR on the use of personal data in AI models. The AI Act also stresses the importance of high-quality datasets for high-risk AI systems to ensure they perform as intended and do not become a source of discrimination.



Ireland's AI governance aligns with the EU AI Act, focusing on harmonized regulation, rights protection, and innovation. National frameworks support sectoral integration, data protection, and ethical standards. Strategic initiatives promote AI literacy, infrastructure, and public-sector transformation, while Ireland contributes to global AI discourse and fosters responsible, trustworthy, and inclusive AI development.



Ireland's Approach to Fostering AI Innovation

Ireland's AI Strategy, "AI – Here for Good," builds on the nation's strong research foundations, robust industrial ecosystem, and societal values to responsibly deploy and govern AI. The strategy emphasizes international leadership in trustworthy AI, human-centric applications, and sustainable innovation, with a firm commitment to European collaboration and global standards.

1. Unlocking Economic Value through Strategic AI Deployment

Ireland is harnessing AI to enhance productivity and innovation across various sectors. The "AI – Here for Good" strategy outlines the goal of positioning Ireland as a leading hub for ethical and trustworthy AI. The AI Advisory Council has recommended developing a national AI-focused start-up ecosystem, which would contribute to unlocking economic value through strategic AI deployment.

2. Driving Innovation via Research Clusters and Application Hubs

The Irish Government supports a network of AI research centers and innovation hubs. The AI Advisory Council's recommendation to develop national AI testbeds across multiple sectors highlights a commitment to fostering collaboration between academia, startups, and large enterprises. These testbeds would operate in parallel with the sandbox framework provided for in the EU AI Act, forming a crucial part of Ireland's AI ecosystem and promoting applied AI research.



3. Enabling Trusted and Responsible Data Use

Ireland's data protection framework, primarily governed by the GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018, promotes secure, ethical access to high-quality data. The Data Protection Commission (DPC) actively focuses on the use of personal data by AI technologies, initiating investigations and publishing guidance on AI, Large Language Models, and Data Protection. This ensures that data usage for AI is aligned with European data protection principles. The AI Act also emphasizes the importance of high-quality datasets for high-risk AI systems to prevent bias and ensure intended performance.

4. Scaling AI in Public Administration

Ireland's public sector is working towards deploying AI to enhance public services. The National AI Strategy emphasizes that the use of AI within the public service must be actively informed by an assessment of potential human rights and equality implications. The AI Advisory Council has also made recommendations regarding the responsible use of AI by An Garda Síochána (Ireland's police force), underscoring the commitment to ethical and legally sound AI adoption in public services.



5. Advancing Compute and Research Infrastructure

Ireland is investing in infrastructure to support AI scale-up. The recommendation from the AI Advisory Council to develop national AI testbeds reflects a commitment to providing the necessary compute and research infrastructure for real-world AI experimentation and advanced model development.

6. Empowering SMEs and Startups

Ireland's approach aims to empower SMEs and startups to integrate AI into their operations. The AI Advisory Council's recommendation to develop a national AI-focused start-up ecosystem is a direct measure to provide support, potentially through advisory services and funding, to lower AI adoption barriers for these enterprises. A study by Ireland's Central Statistics Office in 2024 indicated that while large and medium-sized enterprises commonly use AI, small enterprises mainly use AI for natural language generation, highlighting the need for continued support for broader AI adoption.

7. Developing a Future-Ready Workforce

Ireland promotes AI education and lifelong learning. The AI Act requires employers to ensure their workforce using AI systems for work has a sufficient level of AI literacy. The AI Advisory Council has recommended that the Irish Government lead the development and implementation of AI literacy for educators across all education levels and publish guidelines for the use of generative AI tools, ensuring a future-ready workforce.

8. Aligning AI with Sustainability Goals

While not explicitly detailed in the provided content, Ireland's broader commitment to sustainable development and alignment with EU objectives, such as the European Green Deal, suggests that AI applications would be leveraged to achieve climate neutrality and sustainability goals. The "AI – Here for Good" strategy implicitly supports responsible and beneficial AI development that can contribute to societal well-being, which includes environmental sustainability.

9. Building Public Trust and Ethical AI

The Irish Government embeds ethics into AI through the principles outlined in its "AI – Here for Good" strategy, which aligns with the principles of the AI Act. The establishment of the AI Advisory Council is a key initiative to provide independent advice on AI policy, ensuring a human-centric approach. The DPC's focus on data protection and its guidance on AI also contribute to building public trust by addressing privacy concerns.

10. Shaping Global AI Governance and Standards

Ireland is a proactive player in shaping global AI governance through its participation in the EU and engagement with international bodies. The country supports harmonized EU-level AI regulations, with the AI Act being directly applicable. The DPC's engagement with the European Data Protection Board (EDPB) also demonstrates Ireland's commitment to shaping consistent global AI standards, promoting an "AI made for good" model based on democratic values and human rights.





Figure 1: Objectives of Ireland's National AI Strategy





Digital Decade 2025: Country Report

In 2024, 14.9% of enterprises in Ireland reported adopting AI technologies, a figure that slightly exceeds the EU average of 13.48% but remains below the national target of 75% set for 2030. This marks a notable improvement from 2023, when only 8.01% of firms had integrated AI—an 86% year-on-year increase, compared to the EU's 67.2% growth over the same period. Nevertheless, Ireland is currently behind its intended national trajectory.

Despite this progress, AI adoption is still heavily skewed by company size. While 50.84% of large enterprises have adopted AI, just 13.8% of small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) have done so, creating a 37.04 percentage point gap—significantly higher than the EU average.

To support AI policy development and alignment, the Enterprise Digital Advisory Forum (EDAF) plays a key role. Additionally, CeADAR, Ireland's national centre for applied AI and a node in the European Digital Innovation Hub network, provides training and “test-before-invest” services. In 2024, CeADAR launched specialised training initiatives aimed at enhancing AI literacy in line with the EU AI Act. These efforts received positive responses from both private sector actors and public institutions.

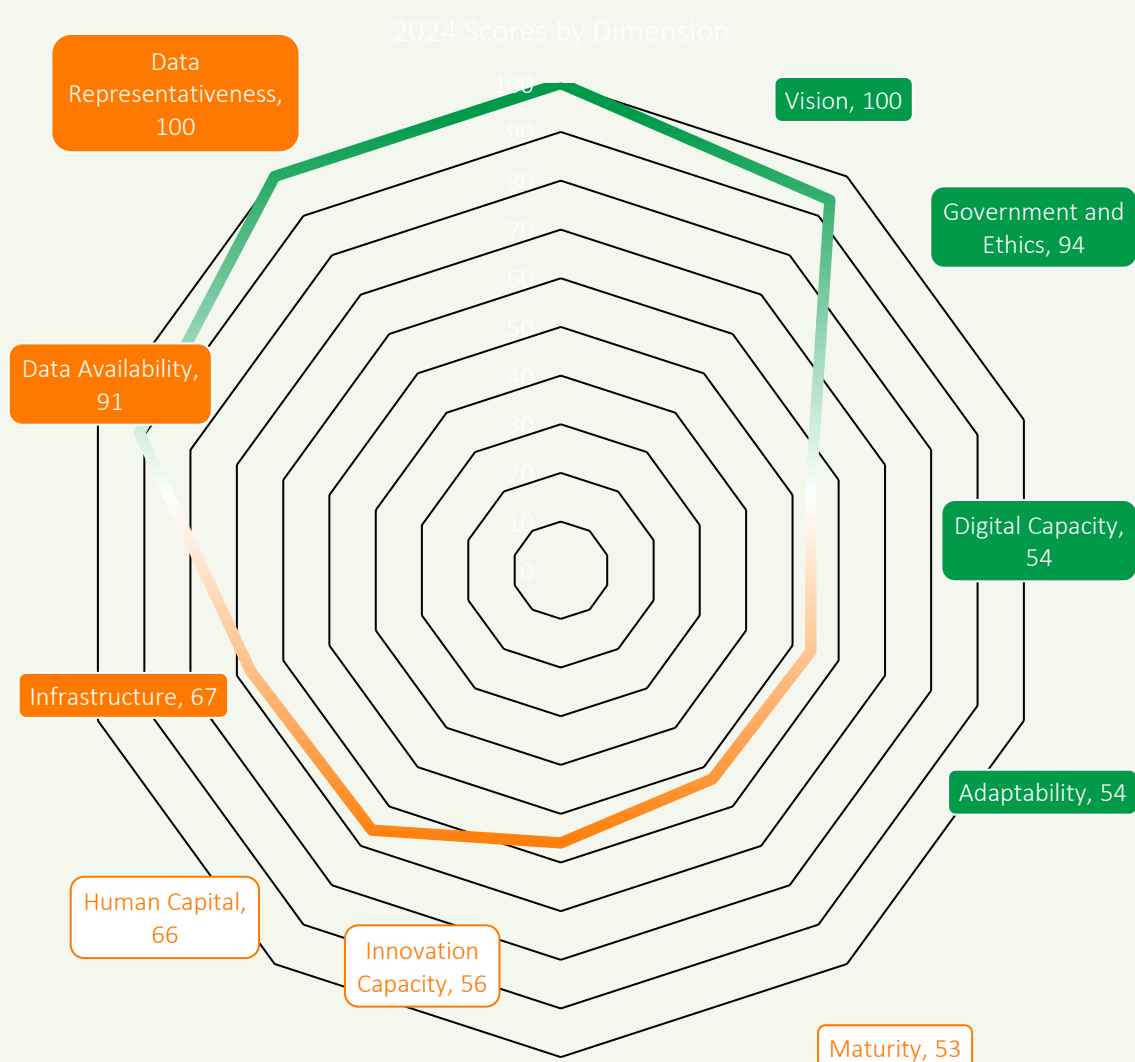
Ireland's national AI strategy, titled AI – Here for Good, continues to serve as the country's guiding framework, promoting the development of ethical, human-centred AI. While implementation remains on schedule, there is still a lack of concrete policies focused on specific use cases or industry-level AI deployment strategies.





Government AI Readiness by Oxford Insights

'Western Europe ranks as the highest-performing region in this year's Government AI Readiness Index, with five countries in the global top 10. France leads the regional ranking with a score of 79.36, narrowly ahead of the United Kingdom (78.88), followed closely by the Netherlands (77.23), Germany (76.90), and Finland (76.48). With an average regional score of 69.56, Western Europe outperforms the global average (47.59) across all three pillars of Government, Technology, and Data & Infrastructure. The region's standout strength is the Data & Infrastructure pillar, where it averages 81.91, more than 21 points above the global benchmark (59.62), reflecting its advanced digital infrastructure and high-quality data environment. Although a few microstates such as San Marino, Liechtenstein, and Andorra fall slightly below the global average in the Government pillar,





Government

Ireland scores 75.47 in the Government pillar, reflecting its structured and EU-aligned approach to AI governance. The EU AI Act serves as the primary regulatory framework, directly applicable in Ireland since February 2, 2025, for prohibited AI practices. Ireland is also pursuing complementary national legislation, with the Regulation of Artificial Intelligence Bill included in its Spring 2025 Legislation Programme, which will aim to implement the EU AI Act domestically. The Irish Data Protection Commission (DPC) has played an active oversight role, issuing guidance on AI and investigating organizations' use of personal data for training AI tools. While Ireland has opted for a distributed model for implementing the AI Act, with an initial list of eight public bodies designated as competent authorities, a lead regulator is expected to be designated for coordination. Combined with the 2021 National AI Strategy, "AI – Here for Good," which emphasizes ethical AI and talent development.

Technology Sector

Ireland's score of 58.13 in the Technology pillar indicates a moderately developed AI innovation environment. The country benefits from a strong academic base and active participation in EU research programs. Initiatives outlined in the National AI Strategy focus on fostering innovation, including the recommendation from the AI Advisory Council to develop a national AI-focused start-up ecosystem and national AI testbeds. Public-private partnerships and university-led research contribute to foundational R&D. While Ireland has growing AI interest, particularly with 15.2% of all Irish enterprises using AI technologies in 2024, more targeted funding and continued policy support for commercialization will be crucial to elevate Ireland's technological competitiveness.



Data & infrastructure Sector

With a score of 85.95, Ireland performs exceptionally strongly in the Data & Infrastructure pillar, driven by solid digital connectivity, cloud infrastructure development, and adherence to EU data protection frameworks, particularly the GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018. The DPC's guidance and strategic alignment with the EU Data Strategy underpin national efforts to promote interoperability and secure data sharing. The AI Advisory Council's recommendation to develop national AI testbeds operating in parallel to the sandbox framework provided for in the AI Act indicates a clear intention to enable experimentation environments for AI within lawful and ethical bounds. Recent policy discussions, highlighted by the DPC's focus on privacy rights and the impact of GDPR on AI systems, emphasize the importance of responsible data use, the protection of personal data in AI training, and ethical uses of data, illustrating Ireland's commitment to trusted data governance.



Conclusion

Ireland's artificial intelligence ecosystem stands at a pivotal point—ready to translate recent regulatory progress, institutional investment, and research consolidation into scalable, equitable, and high-impact outcomes. Anchored in the National AI Strategy ("AI – Here for Good") and reinforced by the proposed national Regulation of Artificial Intelligence Bill and flagship research initiatives, Ireland has laid the groundwork for an AI model rooted in social responsibility, digital sovereignty, and European values. Programs such as the development of national AI testbeds and the emphasis on AI literacy within the National AI Strategy signal Ireland's strategic intent to embed AI in public services, economic transformation, and scientific advancement. The government's focus on high-risk sectors—as classified by the EU AI Act, including employment, healthcare, and law enforcement—reflects a deliberate effort to align AI adoption with ethical safeguards and citizen trust. Nonetheless, structural challenges persist. While Ireland has a growing AI interest, with 15.2% of enterprises using AI technologies, it must improve the commercialization of research outcomes and deepen AI diffusion among SMEs, which may still face barriers in accessing financing, talent, and experimentation environments. The national startup ecosystem, while growing, can benefit from strengthened venture support mechanisms. Piloting regulatory sandboxes (as envisioned in the AI Act) and supporting the development of a national AI-focused start-up ecosystem, as recommended by the AI Advisory Council, will be critical for bridging this innovation gap.

Ireland also faces a pressing need to scale up AI infrastructure—from high-performance computing and federated data systems to interoperable platforms for secure and lawful data sharing. Despite strong performance in the Data & Infrastructure pillar of the AI Readiness Index (85.95), full operationalization of open datasets, trusted data spaces, and sectoral cloud solutions remains a work in progress. Human capital constraints further challenge execution. The emphasis on AI education, including AI literacy for educators, and continuous upskilling programs are promising steps—but must be sustained and scaled. Aligning educational initiatives with applied AI needs will determine Ireland's ability to retain talent and close capability gaps.

On the regulatory front, Ireland's dual-track approach—anchored in the EU AI Act and the proposed national AI Bill—shows strong ambition. Yet institutional clarity is still evolving. The designation of competent authorities, and the role of a lead regulator, must ensure proportional enforcement and SME-oriented compliance support. Sector-specific regulators and the Data Protection Commission (DPC) will need to coordinate closely to ensure effective oversight. Ireland's participation in global AI governance—through the EU and engagement with international bodies—positions it as a principled advocate of trustworthy, rights-based AI. As climate, demographic, and geopolitical pressures converge, Ireland's emphasis on AI for sustainability, inclusion, and democratic integrity could become a model for aligning digital innovation with societal resilience. Ireland has built a solid strategic and institutional base. The next phase demands accelerated, cross-sectoral execution—mobilizing academia, government, SMEs, and civil society in unison. With coherent implementation, decentralized innovation, and proactive international engagement, Ireland can not only reinforce its role in the European AI ecosystem but also shape the global discourse on human-aligned and ethically grounded AI systems.

The infrastructure is in place—the imperative now is action.





Appendix A: Ireland's AI Advantage: A Strategic Perspective on the National Ecosystem Brief



Tony Moroney,
The Digital Explorer ➤

As Europe's AI regulatory framework develops, a small island nation on its western edge is quietly emerging not only as a compliant member state but also as a global exemplar for ethical, innovative, and inclusive AI.

This commentary reviews the draft AI Ecosystem Brief – Ireland (2025), offering strategic guidance and constructive feedback to enhance its contextual basis, strengthen its positioning, and boost its relevance for policymakers, innovators, and institutions alike.

From Silicon Island to AI Vanguard

Ireland's development in the digital economy has been deliberate, steady, and built on decades of adaptable policymaking. Its position is supported by a long-term ICT strategy, from early initiatives like Schools IT 2000 to the deployment of national broadband infrastructure—key efforts that have helped establish a digitally literate, innovation-ready society.

Today, the ICT sector contributes nearly one-fifth of Ireland's Gross Value Added, accounts for 21% of corporate tax revenues, and supports over 6% of national employment—figures that position Ireland firmly at the centre of Europe's digital economy.



The AI Ecosystem Brief highlights Ireland's mid-range human capital score (66), but this arguably underestimates the strategic potential unlocked by its leading tertiary education rates and extensive international talent pool.

Talent, Trust, and Tertiary Dominance

In November 2024, Ireland achieved a significant milestone: it was ranked first in the EU for higher education attainment, with over 62% of adults aged 25–34 holding a degree.

This is more than just a statistical achievement — it is a strategic advantage. In an AI-driven economy where cognitive adaptability, ethical judgment, and technical fluency are vital enablers, Ireland is exceptionally well-placed.

The workforce is also highly international. One in three ICT sector employees is a non-Irish national, highlighting Ireland's appeal as a globally connected, cosmopolitan tech centre. This diversity enriches not only the labour market but also Ireland's capacity to foster dialogue, from AI ethics panels to EU regulatory roundtables. As the AI Ecosystem Brief discusses adoption gaps—particularly among SMEs and public services—this human capital strength acts as a crucial lever for dissemination, experimentation, and cross-sectoral alignment.

Beyond Readiness: Institutional Agility and Regulatory Capital

The AI Ecosystem Brief details Ireland's developing regulatory framework, especially its decentralised model involving multiple competent authorities, as well as the upcoming Regulation of Artificial Intelligence Bill. Although these initiatives are commendable, they reveal areas that need more focus, particularly regarding operational clarity and institutional coherence.

In the era of generative systems and rapid AI expansion, institutional flexibility may be more vital than infrastructure alone. Ireland's distributed model, complemented by its real-time AI Observatory—which tracks labour displacement, capital flows, and skills shifts—indicates a governance system built for responsiveness and feedback.

However, strategic tensions remain. The absence of a designated national AI coordinator or primary enforcement authority raises concerns about regulatory consistency, cross-sector responsibility, and the speed of decision-making.

As the EU AI Act nears implementation, Ireland will require governance frameworks that are not only aligned with Brussels but also transparent to innovators, SMEs, and citizens. Without this clarity, Ireland risks regulatory fragmentation when cohesion is crucial for trust and competitiveness.

From Hosting to Shaping: The FDI Moment Reimagined

Ireland's long-standing role as a host nation for global tech multinationals—16 of the world's top 20 firms maintain a presence here—has solidified its economic growth and international digital influence. However, the next phase is not just about facilitation; it's about exerting influence. Ireland now has the chance to shape the future of AI, rather than merely hosting it.

The IDA Ireland 2025–2029 strategy charts this course, aiming to create 75,000 new jobs, attract €7 billion in R&D and innovation (RD&I) investment, and upskill 40,000 workers. These targets are not just performance indicators; they mark a strategic shift—a deliberate move up the AI value chain, from compliance centres and shared services to globally influential innovation and policy hubs.





To fulfil this promise, Ireland now needs to implement:

- **AI-native innovation campuses**—spaces similar to Station F in Paris, where startups, researchers, and policymakers collaboratively develop regulation-aware, socially aligned AI products.
- **SME-focused enablement platforms**—tools that democratise access to computing, foundation models, and compliance-by-design toolkits, lowering entry barriers for smaller enterprises.
- **Federated sectoral ecosystems and data trusts**—particularly in healthtech, agri-tech, and the green economy—where Ireland’s public-good ethos and regulatory credibility can set new global standards.

These aren’t just institutional investments; they are identity-shaping interventions that will influence Ireland’s standing in the global AI economy.

An Ethical Edge in a Competitive World

In a multipolar AI race—where some countries prioritise speed over safety and scale over scrutiny—Ireland’s commitment to ethics, transparency, and public value may seem idealistic. However, that perception is precisely its strength.

A “good” AI strategy is not just a branding exercise. It serves as a strategic asset—a blueprint for how smaller, agile states can leverage regulatory capital: the blend of legal clarity, societal legitimacy, and trusted market access needed to shape global norms and influence the frontier of rulemaking.

In this moment of flux, trust is not a limitation; it is a form of strategic advantage.

Ireland’s AI Advantage: A Strategic Synthesis

Pillar	Strength	Strategic Implication
Education	EU’s highest tertiary attainment	Talent depth for sustained AI diffusion
Tech Ecosystem	270,000+ tech workers, top firms anchored (IDA, 2025)	Launchpad for AI-first innovation
Policy Agility	Proactive AI regulation, observatory in development	Model for responsive governance
Global Trust	Values-led narrative, GDPR legacy	Exportable ethical frameworks
Scale & Cohesion	Small nation, coordinated stakeholders	Testbed for fast, federated experimentation
Legal & Linguistic	Only native English-speaking country in EU; common law system	Strong alignment with US/UK digital norms and legal frameworks
Business Environment	Competitive corporate tax rate; pro-FDI policy	Attractive base for AI-intensive investment and operations

A Test Nation for the Next Era of AI

Ireland’s history as an ICT pioneer and digital diplomat offers a unique opportunity: to establish itself as Europe’s trusted testbed for next-generation AI governance and deployment.

It possesses not only the technological infrastructure, regulatory maturity, and talent base, but also the cultural legitimacy to lead bold, inclusive experimentation in how societies interact with AI. The world doesn’t just need faster or smarter AI. It requires a model that is human-centred, value-driven, and embedded within society. And that model might very well begin in Ireland.

As the AI Ecosystem Brief approaches its final stages, it faces a key decision: to position Ireland not just as a willing adopter but as a policy pioneer and institutional innovator—locally grounded, globally influential, and prepared to take the lead.



Appendix B: Ireland's AI Readiness: A Strategic Brief on Ethics, Innovation & Global Positioning



Matthew Kilkenny 
AI Ethics Ambassador

Executive Summary

Ireland stands at a historic crossroads in the AI supercycle. As global norms, regulations, and technologies evolve at unprecedented pace, we have a unique opportunity—not just to comply—but to lead.

This brief offers a strategic lens on Ireland's AI readiness across regulation, enterprise adoption, international posture, and ethical infrastructure. It draws on live government updates, emerging policy data (including EDRIX 2025), and frontline signals from those engaging deeply with Europe's evolving AI landscape.

With our EU Council Presidency on the horizon, and global trust in short supply, Ireland's edge lies not in scale—but in conviction, credibility, and coherence. This contribution aims to map what's happening, why it matters, and how we can lead with both confidence and conscience.



1. AI Summit 2026 – Ireland's Moment to Lead

The AI Summit in 2026 is more than a showcase—it's a declaration of intent. It offers Ireland a strategic platform to position itself as a policy shaper, not just a policy taker

Planned for Q3 or Q4 of 2026, the Global AI Summit will serve as a flagship event during Ireland's EU Council Presidency, which begins on 1 July 2026. The summit is designed to showcase Ireland's institutional readiness for the EU AI Act, highlighting progress on the National AI Office, regulatory sandboxes, enterprise engagement, and public sector preparedness. Its timing is strategic: not preceding the presidency, but embedded within it—positioning Ireland as a reputational springboard for ethical AI leadership across Europe and beyond.

2. Central AI Office & Observatory – Coordinating with Credibility

Leadership in AI requires visible, capable coordination. The National Artificial Intelligence Office (NAIO) gives Ireland the institutional backbone to govern AI with coherence and agility

Launched in September 2025, the NAIO—under the Department of Enterprise—is tasked with national coordination of AI policy, implementation of the EU AI Act, and alignment with broader EU strategies such as the AI Factories initiative. A Director General will be appointed later in the year. The Office will serve as the core integrator between regulators, enterprise, and civil society.

3. EU AI Act Implementation – From Fragmented to Functional

Proper enforcement of the EU AI Act is what will differentiate compliance from leadership. Ireland has now formalised the regulatory framework, but the next challenge is integration

In July 2025, Ireland enacted the European Union (Artificial Intelligence) (Designation) Regulations 2025 (SI No. 366), formally appointing sectoral regulators and designating the Minister for Enterprise as the single point of contact. Authorities include the Central Bank, DPC, HPRA, and others. While enforcement is distributed, the NAIO will serve a central coordinating role. A national market surveillance system is under development.

4. AI Sandbox – Safe Innovation, Real Impact

To foster ethical innovation, Ireland must not only regulate AI—but also enable it. Regulatory sandboxes do exactly that: they support responsible testing, especially for SMEs

In alignment with the EU AI Act, Ireland is rolling out sector-specific sandboxes. SMEs are prioritized, with access to simplified compliance routes and structured guidance. These sandboxes will also act as early testbeds for evaluating high-risk applications, further proving Ireland's leadership in implementation.

5. National AI Strategy – Turning Policy into Productivity

Strategic plans matter—but implementation is what earns trust. Ireland's refreshed AI strategy is now showing measurable impact in the enterprise sector

The 'AI: Here for Good' strategy (updated in November 2024) includes initiatives like the Grow Digital Portal, enhanced CeADAR supports, and active engagement from the National Productivity Council. Enterprise AI adoption rose from 8% to 14.9% between 2023 and 2024—a clear indicator that policy and infrastructure are converging.





6. Global & EU Positioning – Small Nation, Smart Strategy

Ireland continues to punch above its weight in tech diplomacy. Our influence lies not in scale, but in our ethical stance, agile governance, and ability to convene.

Ireland is preparing for its 2026 EU Council Presidency while also establishing an AI Factory Antenna—linking with Europe’s AI infrastructure. Ministerial outreach includes Asia Tech x Singapore and bilateral AI agreements. Ireland’s positioning as a neutral, trusted hub for responsible AI development remains a strategic asset.

7. Key Indicators – Progress at a Glance

Area	Status
AI Summit 2026	Confirmed; will serve as a leadership and readiness showcase
AI Office & Observatory	NAIO launched; coordinating policy and EU alignment
EU AI Act Compliance	Designation Regulations in force; enforcement is decentralised
AI Sandbox	Rolling out with SME priority and innovation-first framework
SME Support	Online tools, sandbox access, and simplified guidance active
Enterprise Adoption	14.9% AI uptake in 2024; infrastructure and portals scaling
Global Engagement	EU Council prep, bilateral outreach, AI Factory Antenna in motion

8. Outlook & Final Reflections

Ireland’s AI journey is accelerating, but the next phase will demand more than good intentions. We must demonstrate that we can scale coordination, manage distributed enforcement, and maintain our values while facing complex global headwinds.

Our educated workforce, thriving tech sector, and global trust profile give us a unique competitive advantage. Ireland is now a serious contender to be the benchmark for ethical, innovation-driven AI policy in Europe.

Yet we must remain vigilant. Rising geopolitical tensions—including U.S. pushback against EU AI regulation—highlight the fragile balance between global cooperation and national interest. The EDRIX 2025 findings further underscore that if we fail to connect talent with sovereign strategy, we won’t just fall behind—we’ll lose the right to lead. Can Ireland remain both a principled actor and a pragmatic partner as global AI norms are contested? That’s the challenge—and the opportunity.

9. Digital Resilience & Strategic Gaps – A Wake-Up Call

Ireland’s low ranking in the newly released European Digital Resilience Index (EDRIX 2025) is not just a data point—it’s a challenge to our national narrative on digital leadership. It reveals a dissonance between our deep talent pool and the coherence of our strategy around digital sovereignty and open technologies. EDRIX 2025 offers the EU’s first data-driven benchmark for digital resilience, ranking member states across five strategic pillars: Public Policy, Developer Ecosystem, Grassroots Adoption, Private Sector Digital Health, and Public Sector Digital Health.

While countries like Germany (7.80), Czech Republic (6.89), and Sweden (6.80) lead the index, Ireland scored just 3.10 overall—yet placed in the top five for Developer Ecosystem strength. This stark contrast underscores a key concern: we have the human capital, but lack strategic alignment. This gap points to a systemic vulnerability. Without stronger alignment between national policy, infrastructure, and open technology strategies, Ireland risks missing its opportunity to lead not just in AI adoption, but in digital independence and trust. With its unique blend of technical talent and principled leadership, Ireland is well positioned not just to meet the challenge—but to lead the world in this AI supercycle.





Appendix C: Expert Vignettes



Marie O'Riordan

The Croí Initiative



“



Ireland is implementing the EU AI Act through 15 designated authorities, with a National AI Office to be established by August 2026. I believe enforcement capacity across these bodies will be the swing factor through 2025 to 2026. The refreshed National AI Strategy, released in November 2024, remains the policy base. Key rules are phasing in on schedule, including prohibitions and AI literacy from February 2025, governance and general-purpose AI duties from August 2025 and most remaining obligations by August 2026. Industry momentum is evident, as seen by Equifax's AI innovation lab in Wexford, which opened in September 2025. As of October 2025, grid capacity is tight, especially around Dublin, where EirGrid has indicated limited scope for new connections before 2028. The regulator's proposed Large Energy Users policy steers new data centres toward locations with capacity and requires on-site or proximate generation, storage and flexibility. Data centres accounted for 22% of metered electricity in 2024, revealing the pressure. My prediction is that Ireland's competitive edge will come from credible AI assurance and audit capability, while grid timelines set the pace of scale-up.

”

Biography

Marie O'Riordan is a Senior Partner at The Croí Initiative, including Croí Impact & Croí Capital, a global strategic adviser, journalist and broadcaster, crisis adviser to leading international organisations, keynote speaker on 5 continents, a Forbes Councils member publishing content on Forbes.com since 2020 and has recently returned from New York City after events around the 80th United Nations General Assembly (UNGA80), including the 20th anniversary of the Clinton Global Initiative, where AI featured prominently.



Hugo Grattirola

Philip Lee LLP



“



Ireland's regulatory approach to AI is pragmatic yet ambitious, balancing robust GDPR enforcement with progressive government strategy, anticipating the EU AI Act, and fostering an innovative, globally competitive AI ecosystem.

”

Biography

Hugo Grattirola is a Partner in the corporate/commercial and the data, privacy, and technology teams in Philip Lee LLP. He is a fully qualified lawyer in both Ireland and France. Hugo specialises in technology matters such as Artificial Intelligence and Data Protection/Privacy. Hugo regularly assists clients on their path to compliance with data protection legislation and any data protection matters arising from commercial contracts. Hugo is CIPP/E certified (Certified Information Privacy Professional). He regularly speaks at seminars and lectures on the area of Data Protection/Privacy and often conducts workshops and training sessions on the practical implications of data protection legislation..



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